



(12) **United States Plant Patent**
Zwetzig

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(54) **HIBISCUS PLANT NAMED: ‘LITTLE PRINCE’**

(50) Latin Name: *Hibiscus moscheutos*×*H. coccineus*
Varietal Denomination: **Little Prince**

(76) Inventor: **Gretchen Zwetzig**, Lindsay, CA (US)

(*) Notice: Subject to any disclaimer, the term of this patent is extended or adjusted under 35 U.S.C. 154(b) by 92 days.

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(65) **Prior Publication Data**

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(52) **U.S. Cl.** **Plt./257**

(58) **Field of Classification Search** **Plt./257**
See application file for complete search history.

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(57) **ABSTRACT**

A new and distinct cultivar of winter hardy hibiscus plant named ‘Little Prince’ is the result of a unique hybridization. This new and distinct cultivar is characterized primarily as to its novelty by its extreme cold hardiness to Zone 4, large tri-colored, purple-red-pink, thick textured flowers and its “Maple-shaped” foliage with a purple coloration, compactness of approximately 2½ feet, its vigorous and uniform breaking habit and its floriferous nature from midsummer until frost.

2 Drawing Sheets

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Latin Name: *Hibiscus moscheutos*×*H. coccineus*.
Varietal denomination: ‘Little Prince’, hardy *Hibiscus*.

FIELD OF THE INVENTION

This plant, as a hybridized hardy *Hibiscus*, is valuable to the landscape market for its improvements in thicker textured and brightly, tri-colored flowers and buds, refined “maple-like” foliage with a purple-green color, its all-around vigor, good compact breaking action, and adaptation to extreme environments, including the ability to consistently survive winter temperatures of at least –30 degrees Fahrenheit.

BACKGROUND OF THE NEW PLANT

The new plant of this invention is the result of a unique hybridization, with the breeding achievement being evidenced in the outstanding combination of characteristics exhibited by this new and distinct *Hibiscus* plant, which include:

- Refined, 3-5 lobed “maple-shaped” leaves with a slight purple-green color and relatively smooth margins which combined compliments the landscape;
- Medium to large-sized flowers that are outstanding for their purple and pink colored, heavily speckled petals;
- The plant being very floriferous with flowers that stay open for at least one to two days;
- The plant being small but vigorous with compact and uniform breaking action which gives it unique landscape utility; and
- The plant being so hardy that it can consistently withstand winter temperatures of at least –30 degrees Fahrenheit.

SUMMARY OF THE INVENTION

‘Little Prince’ was the result of a 50-year breeding program. Its ancestry includes *Hibiscus moscheutos* and *Hibiscus coccineus*. More specifically, the plant resulted from mul-

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tiple crossings with an unnamed, Fleming-bred *Hibiscus moscheutos* (non patented) and an unnamed Fleming-bred *Hibiscus coccineus* (non patented). The seedling which most nearly met all of the above standards was selected.

5 This new plant first bloomed in the summer of 2001 and was selected by Gretchen Zwetzig on her property located at 8101 S. 14th St. 68512 Lincoln, Nebr. (previous address for applicants). Asexual propagation of the plant by cuttings and root division in Lincoln, Nebr. has shown that the unique and distinguishing features of the plant are faithfully transmitted from generation to generation and appear to be fixed.

10 Since its origin, the plant has bloomed from midsummer until frost, while exhibiting the aforementioned distinctive characteristics. This hardy *Hibiscus* plant greatly contributes to the market with its, sheer beauty and utter refinement, its compact growth habit, its enhanced resistance to disease and insects, its stability through extremes in rain and drought, and its extreme hardiness.

20 **BRIEF DESCRIPTION OF THE DRAWINGS**

The flower and foliage of the cultivar at 2½ years of age are shown in the attached photographs.

25 More specifically, FIG. 1 is a close-up of the flower and the leaf.

FIG. 2 is a depiction of the whole plant.

30 The colors are as true as is reasonably possible to attain in photographic illustrations of this type. The colors illustrated may be slightly off due to light reflectance.

DESCRIPTION OF THE NEW PLANT

35 What follows is a detailed description of the new cultivar. The specific color descriptions are in accordance with The Royal Horticultural Society Colour Chart (2001), while general color recitations are consistent with ordinary American terminology.

‘Little Prince’ has not been observed under all possible environmental conditions. It is to be understood that the phe-

notype may vary significantly with variations in the environment such as temperature, light intensity, humidity, and day length without, however any difference in genotype of the plant. The following botanical characteristics and observations are gathered from the plant when grown in Lincoln, Nebr. (USDA Zone 4) and Lindsay, Calif. (USDA Zone 9).

THE PLANT

Parentage:

Seed parent.—*Hibiscus moscheutos*, unnamed and unpatented Fleming-bred seedling.

Pollen parent.—*Hibiscus coccineus*, unnamed and unpatented Fleming-bred seedling.

Comparison between observed plant and parents: Parents were similar, except for being approximately ½ foot taller in height than Observed Plant and has less purple in the flower.

Comparison between observed plant and other known cultivars: The Observed Plant is unique, but most similar to 'Fantasia' U.S. Plant Pat. No. 11,853 and our patented hardy *Hibiscus*, in that: (a) they are all more compact at 3 feet on average. (b) they are all hardy to -30 degrees Fahrenheit. (c) they all have refined new leaf shapes and colors. (d) they all have thick, overlapping new flower colors with blooms from the top to the bottom of the plant. But, 'Little Prince' has a bi-colored flower.

Origin: A selected seedling from stated cross.

Type of plant: Hardy, herbaceous perennial.

Classification: Variety of hardy *Hibiscus* plant.

Propagation: Relatively easy to propagate through cuttings; holds its distinguishing characteristics through successive cuttings and divisions.

Size: About 2½ feet tall and about 2½ feet wide. 30 inches tall when measured.

Form: Symmetrical annual growth from perennial roots.

Habit: Upright and uniformly branched.

Growth: Vigorous; medium and compact. Full grown (2½ ft) in 2 years.

Hardiness: Hardy to at least -30 degrees Fahrenheit.

General health: Plant is very disease resistant against rot, aphids, spider mites, scale, white fly etc.; sturdy through excessive drought, rain or wind.

Propagation: Relatively easy and fast rooting in approximately 2 weeks.

Foliage:

1. *Arrangement.*—Alternate.

2. *Shape.*—Juvenile: 3-5 lobed "maple-shaped" leaves. Rounded base shape. Mature: Refined, "maple-shaped", 3-5 lobed leaf with entire to mildly serrate margins and acute apices; rounded base.

3. *Size.*—Mature leaf (petiole base to apex): Length is about 5 inches or (12.5 cm), width is about 4 inches or (10 cm). Young leaf: Length 2¾ inches or (7 cm), width is 1½ inches or (3.8 cm).

4. *Color.*—Young leaves (upper side): A little darker than 147-A; (purple cast): N77-A. Mature leaves: (upper side): Blend of 175 A and N77-A. Veins: 59-A and 148 A. Venation pattern: Palmate. Mature leaf Venation Color: 59-A and 148-A. Upper and Lower. Coloration of the Mature lower leaf surface: Between 137-C and 147-B with 59-A (veins).

5. *Surface texture.*—Upper: Smooth. Lower: Semi-smooth.

6. *Petiole length.*—About 2¾ inches or 6.985 cm. Diameter: 1-2 cm.

7. *Petiole color.*—137-A and 59-A. Surface texture: Semi-smooth.

5 Stems: The stems are stout at the base becoming more slender toward the apices; coloration is consistent with the petiole.

Length: 2-3 inches. Diameter: 1-2 cm.

Internode length: Approximately 2 inches.

Texture: Semi-smooth.

The Flower

Blooming period: Profuse from June to July until frost, depending on the region of U.S.

15 Flower diameter: Large; about 10 inches (25.4 cm).

Borne: Singly in leaf axils, from midpoint of stems upward.

Bloom duration: Individual bloom lasts at least one to two full days.

20 Form: Campanulate; petals are also very overlapping.

Average number of flowers per season: 300.

Bud:

1. *Length.*—About 2¼ inches or (5.715 cm) on day before opening. Diameter: apx. 2 inches.

2. *Color.*—Between N 57-A and N 66-A.

3. *Surface texture.*—Semi-glabrous.

4. *Duration.*—One to two weeks.

Corolla: Having five petals. 8-10 inches.

1. *Petal character and dimensions.*—Campanulate and very overlapping. (a) Length: About 4¾ inches or (12 cm). (b) Width: About 5½ inches or (14 cm).

2. *Tri-coloration.*—Purple and pink N 57-A, N 57-B, N 57-C; 85-B (purple). (a) Markings (Speckles) on petal surface: (Front and back): N57-A, B and C; Margins: N 57-A and B. Backside (reverse) coloration of petal surface: N 57-A, B, C and 85-B. Middle of flower (between eye zone and edges): 85-B. (b) Venation in petals: N 57-A, B, C and 85-D. Upper and Lower. (c) Bi-colored Eye zone: Inner: 187-A and B. Outer: N 57-A and N 66-A. Size: 3 inches or (7.5 cm).

3. *Texture.*—Smooth.

4. *Substance.*—Thick.

5. *Shape.*—Campanulate and very overlapping with slight up ruffle at petal edges.

Reproductive organs:

1. *Staminal column.*—Stamen along basal two-thirds. One per flower. Staminal column average length: About 2½ inches or (6.5 cm). Filaments: apx 100. Length: 1¼", 3.175 cm. Stamen color Designation: 63-A and 64-B. Pollen color: 11-B.

2. *Style.*—Terminates upper one-third of staminal column. 1" in length. Color: N 66 A. Stigmatic lobe color: Blend of N 66-A and 53-A. Stigma ½", 1.27 cm.

Calyx:

Shape.—5 lobed, connate at the base; about 1¼ inches or (3.175 cm) in length. One per flower.

Upper and lower surface Color.—Medium green: 147-A.

Upper and lower surface texture.—Semi-smooth.

Stipules: None.

Seed (fruit):

Size.—1 cm.

Color.—Grey-brown.

Average number.—Less than 100.

Epicalyx: Whorl of bracts.

- 1. *Shape*.—10-12 slender, sword-shaped bractlets.
- 2. *Length*.—About 1½ inches or (3.8 cm).
- 3. *Upper and lower Color*.—144-A.

Peduncle:

- 1. *Length*.—About 2 inches or (5.08 cm). Diameter: 1 cm.
- 2. *Strength*.—Stiff and sturdy. Surface texture: Semi-smooth.

- 3. *Color*.—Light to medium green with slight purple cast. 148-A and N 77-A.

The invention claimed is:

- 1. A new and distinct cultivar of hardy *Hibiscus* plant, as
5 herein shown and described, characterized by its extremely compact nature, refined “maple-shaped” foliage of a greenish-purple coloration, its large tri-colored and speckled, purple and pink flowers, its vigor and its hardiness.

* * * * *

Figure 1



Figure 2

